We're very excited to have you here! We hope you enjoy your study abroad in the South of France as part of the California State University International Program.

As an alumna of the program, here are the tips and tricks I've learned after 1 year in Aix-en-Provence.

The city of Aix-en-Provence

Aix-en-Provence is an affluent university town, attracting both college students and those with high-paying jobs or even older retirees. Aix is known for its "bobo" shopping culture (or "bougie" as we say in English, but "bougie" in French means candle. "Bobo" is a more familiar term so make sure to only say it around friends). Aix was nicknamed "Le Petit Paris" for this very reason.

The great thing about Aix-en-Provence is that it is a very sheltered city, so you can feel safer walking the streets at night with friends compared to when you are in Marseille. However, still take basic precautions, as always.

Where should I shop in Aix-en-Provence?

When you first arrive, **do not buy coats or essentials in traditional stores in Aix unless they are reasonably priced**. As you move through the city, you will come to learn what is and what isn't a good price, or "bon marché", but typically your expenses will cost you less here in Europe than they do in California. The clothing markets on Thursday and on Saturday go until the mid-afternoon and are a great option if you need cheap clothes. I was able to find a winter coat for 20€ and it lasted me the whole year.

There is typically some sort of "marché" every day, whether that be a farmers market, a flower market, or a clothing market. Check out the days and locations of these street markets here: https://www.aixenprovencetourism.com/en/shopping/the-provencal-markets/

For a cheaper outlet mall compared to the outlet mall in Aix, I recommend visiting **"Plan de Campagne"** which is in a town called Cabriès, the midway point between Aix and Marseille. (Accessible by the 51 bus.) There are some great department stores where you can buy essentials such as coats, basic T-shirts, shoes, etc.

My Favorite Spots in Aix:

♡ For a very French escargot experience at a reasonable price, check out "Le Bouche à Oreille" https://le-bouche-a-oreille-aix-en-provence.com/fr

♡ My 2 favorite bookstores in Aix are Mon Chat Pitre (a cat bookstore, found here: https://www.monchatpitre.com/) and Book & Bar, which is an international bookstore geared towards English, but they also have other translations in other languages on the second floor. (https://www.bookinbar.com/) Here I was able to find a translation of "Le Petit Prince" in Spanish, for example.

♡ Le Festival, the restaurant located right in front of the famous fountain "La Rotonde" (67 Bis Rue Espariat, 13100 Aix-en-Provence, France), has a "Le Petit Déjeuner" deal where you can get a coffee, fresh-squeezed orange juice, waffle or crêpe all for 8-10€, depending on what you order. It is a nice typical French breakfast experience that I like to take my invitees to when they are in town visiting me.

There are lots of great bars, restaurants, and thrifting in Aix. Have fun exploring and take your pick!

(Side note: vegans and vegetarians might have a harder time finding food in restaurants, but France is much more accommodating to different dietary needs than they were pre-Pandemic. There are lots of great restaurants in towns that will have options for you, such as Falafel places, and you can always ask them to take out the meat or dairy and substitute it with something else, if possible. The "Restau U", or the university cafeteria, also has vegan and halal options. However, as a former vegetarian myself, I highly recommend maybe taking a break while you're in France. After all, meat and cheese are a huge part of French cuisine and culture, and being able to eat them really helps you to get the full immersive experience. Furthermore, French cuisine is one of the only two cultural cuisines protected by UNESCO.)

Rent and Rental Assistance

We will have 2 weeks of student housing available when you arrive so please do not book any hotels or Air BnBs beforehand. However, if you'd like to start looking to secure housing for after the two week period, you may do so before you arrive but make sure to not pay any fees or sign any contracts unless you are 100% sure. Because of this, it is best to wait until after you arrive to secure housing so you can tour the apartment in person.

What is a reasonable price for rent?

Rent in Aix-en-Provence should be approximately 400€ to 800€, which is a big difference with the average rent in California. 400€ should get you a room in a "collocation" (shared apartment with roommates) and often doesn't include utilities, while 800€ is more for host family situations or for a student residence, which often includes water, heating, electricity, Wi-Fi, and sometimes meals. As a student myself, I do not recommend paying anything above 900€ for rent. Sometimes landlords will overcharge Americans because they assume we all have money.

If you are interested in applying for a host family check out this agency [However, CSU does have some personal host family contacts as well]: https://www.homestay-aix-en-provence.com/

(For the host family option, it is best to go for 3-5 meals a week rather than the full 7 meals to give you some flexibility with travel; there will also occasionally be CSU excursions on the weekend. As mentioned above, CSU can also provide you some contacts for host families without paying the agency fee.)

Can I get rental assistance as a foreign exchange student?

If you are paying rent and living in the same accommodation in France for at least 8 months out of the year, you may be eligible to apply for rental assistance as a foreign exchange student thanks to CAF. If you already know you are staying in the same accommodation for the whole year (or at least 8 months), apply right away so you can get approved as soon as possible! It may take several months for your assistance to come in.

Check out this article here for more information: Applying for the CAF as an international student – Lodgis Blog Apply here: Student housing aid | Bienvenue sur Caf.fr

Finances in France

Do I need to open a bank account in France?

If your American bank account has a traveling credit card with no international fees, you most likely will not need to open up a French bank account in order to pay your landlord or buy groceries. For transfers from a US bank account to a French one, you can use **Wise.com** or **Remitly.com.**

However, if you do not have a credit/debit card with no international fees, opening up a bank account might be a good option, since those Currency Conversion fees can add up in the long run. (Around 15% every time you use your card in a store, depending on your bank.)

Which French bank is the best to open an account?

BNP Paribas is the friendliest bank for foreign exchange students, since they require less documents than other French banks do. The branch on Cours Sextius (6 Cr Sextius, 13100 Aix-en-Provence, France) is the easiest one to get an appointment for, and sometimes if they're not busy they will even let you open an account on the spot. Additionally, BNP Paribas is a "partenariat" with the University of Aix-Marseille, so if you show them your AMU student card or your "Certificat de Scolarité" you will not have to pay the typical annual bank fees associated with opening an account.

If French isn't your strong suit, the bank members typically speak English, so no need to fret. If you still feel out of your element, however, maybe ask one of the directors of the program to accompany you or a friend who speaks French.

How can I exchange my USD for Euros?

If you have American cash you want to convert to Euros, do so while downtown in Aix, not at the airport. You can lose up to 30% of your money if you exchange your cash for Euros in an airport. There are a couple Currency exchanges right on Cours Mirabeau, as well as many ATMs that you can use your American bank card to withdraw Euros from (for a small fee, of course.)

Bus Passes

What is a “Carte Jeune” and how can I apply for one?

If you are 26 years old and under, you can apply for a “Carte Jeune” for the buses, which would allow you to travel to and from Marseille and Aix-en-Provence **as many times as you want in a 24 hour period for only 2€**.

To apply for this free bus card (i.e. no subscription required), you will first need an official photo ID printed by a Photomaton, which costs 8€. (While this might seem pricey at first, remember that a round trip to Marseille normally costs 14€, so it will save you tant d’argent–AKA lots of money in the long run.) You can find a Photomaton in the Carrefour next to the CSU office on Travers du Cirque or in the larger Monoprix located on Cours Mirabeau. Click on Official Photo then choose the physical copy/print option. Take your printed photos as well as a document of official identification (a Driver’s license or Passport) to L'Accueil (Customer Service) at La Gare Routière (the bus station you arrived at if you took the L40 from the Airport Marseille-Provence).
Once they give you your bus card, your Carte Jeune, you will be able to take it to a bus ticket machine next to the 50 bus (the bus to Marseille). Place your card on the allotted scanner on the machine. From here you will be able to buy a 24 hour 2€ pass to Marseille. **It is not possible to purchase this pass on the bus itself**, so make sure to buy the ticket before you board the bus and scan your bus card once aboard or else they will try to charge you a 7€ ticket for a one-way trip.

This is the same photo process you will need to complete if you will be purchasing a bus subscription.

Which bus subscriptions are available?

There is a **monthly subscription** that costs 30€ for the Aix-en-Provence metropole for those that are only staying one semester in Aix-en-Provence (either returning to the United States or doing a second semester in Paris.)

For those who are staying for 2 semesters, there are 2 main types of “abonnement annuel”, or a year long subscription, for the bus pass. The first is only for the city of Aix-en-Provence (Abonnement Étudiant 100€), and the second is for the entire region of Marseille/Aix-en-Provence (Abonnement Pass Métropole 365 jours Étudiant 360€). For the Marseille/Aix-en-Provence regional annual subscription, you would no longer need to pay for any of the buses, metros, or trams in the entire region, nor would you no longer have to pay 2€ to go to Marseille with your Carte Jeune. This is the best option for those who want to go to and from Marseille frequently, ideally 3-4x per week to get your money’s worth.

Click here to see the regional bus subscription online:

https://www.aixenbus.fr/fr/vE2-Quel-titre-choisir-3F.html (Click on -Moins de 26 ans and -Voyager regulièrement)

Are the annual bus passes discounted for students?

Yes, the two annual bus passes are discounted for you as a student, so in order to prove you're a student at the customer service center at La Gare Routière, please download to your phone or print out your "Certificat de Scolarité" that was uploaded to your CSU portal. It should be listed under your documents as part of your "Arrival Letters."

How do I navigate the bus system?

You can download the app **Moovit** to help with bus navigation and bus routes on your mobile device or you can go directly to their website moovitapp.com. Google Maps and Apple Maps will also be able to tell you bus times but they won't be as accurate as Moovit since Moovit automatically updates the bus schedules if there are disturbances such as protests or strikes, also known as "manifestations" and "grèves". As you might be able to guess, these can happen quite often in France.

The Train System - SNCF 🚆

SNCF is the national railway in France and it stands for "Société nationale des chemins de fer français," which translates to National Society of French Railroads. One of my favorite songs in French is a remix of the SNCF sound you will hear on the loudspeaker before any train ride. Check out "Train pour Bandol" here:

Is there a "Carte Jeune" for the train system in France?

Yes! If you are 28 years old or under, there is also a "Carte Jeune" for the national train system in France. If you would like to travel throughout the year and on the weekends in France for a lower price, by paying 49€ for the annual SNCF Carte Jeune subscription, you will have access to fixed discounted train fares as well as 30% off on all TGV tickets (Train de Grande Vitesse, which can take you to directly from Aix-en-Provence to Paris in around 3 hours).

Click here for more information: Carte Avantage Jeune - SNCF Connect (sncf-connect.com)

There is also a "Carte Zou" for students up until the age of 25, which gives discounts on regional buses and trains for the southern region of Provence-Alpes-Côtes d'Azur.
https://zou.maregionsud.fr

What is the TGV station in Aix-en-Provence?

Here in Aix-en-Provence we are lucky to have a TGV (Train de Grande Vitesse, or Train of Great Speed) station located nearby. This particular kind of train, thanks to its high speeds, can take you to locations such as Paris or Lyon in about half the time anticipated in a regular train.

In order to get to the TGV station in Aix-en-Provence, take the 40 bus at the Gare Routière.

How do I get back to the airport?

If you are trying to reach the Airport Marseille-Provence, you would also take the 40 bus from the Gare Routière, but be careful and **make sure that the 40 bus you are taking has the Airport destination written on it**. Some of the 40 buses only stop at the TGV station, which is the 1st stop, whereas the other 40 buses will take you all the way to the airport (the 2nd stop.) If you are unsure which 40 bus is the correct one, feel free to ask the bus driver. Either way, the 1st stop on the bus will always be TGV.

Unless you have a bus subscription, this bus will cost 10€.

The city of Marseille

Marseille is the 2nd largest city in France in terms of population, right behind Paris. It takes only about a 30 minute ride in the bus to get there from Aix when there's no traffic. **Since it is a major city, be extremely careful with your belongings.** Do not put your phone in a jacket or jean pocket. Always look to make sure your purse zipper is closed, and maybe consider buying a fanny pack (un sac banane / une banane in French) or a purse with a flap so that your wallet and phone are less easily accessible to thieves. Do not use your phone on the metro where people can easily grab it while you're scrolling through social media and then run.

Never leave your phone sitting on a table at a restaurant. Don't walk alone at night in alleyways. Try to always go with a friend. Etc. If you grew up in a big city, these tips may seem obvious, but cell phone theft is common here in Europe, so keep an eye out.

Now that we're through the precautions, let's get to the good stuff: Marseille is my favorite city in France. There are so many fun, cool, and exciting things to do in Marseille that I cannot do in Aix-en-Provence. "Ça bouge" as they say in French, which translates to "it moves" or "it's bustling."

My Favorite Spots in Marseille:

♡My favorite areas to check out are Vieux Port and Cours Julien. Vieux Port is the old port in Marseille, right next to the water and in front of the mayor's office, or La Mairie. It is often the chosen location for many city-wide events such as festivals and parades. Cours Julien is a very cool street with lots of graffiti, cute Instagramable scenery and neon signs, chalk-full of "indie" bars and restaurants. It has also been a highly rated neighborhood in many travel magazines. Both of these locations are accessible by metro.

♡Notre Dame de la Garde is the best viewpoint in the city. It is a historical and very beautiful church that the Pope himself recently visited. You can get up the hill using the bus stop near the Vieux Port. Check Moovit to see which buses are available that day.

♡If you're looking for a traditional mall to go shopping, I recommend the shopping mall called "Les Terrasses du Port" near the metro stop La Joliette (Métro ligne 2 or M2).

♡Museums in Marseille: Every first Sunday of the month, all public museums in France are free! Marseille has some really great public museums, such as MUCEM which is right along the Vieux Port. The two museums at the Palais Longchamp, the art museum and the natural history museum, are free year-round.

♡If you're looking for a Mediterranean island experience, including more private beaches to swim on, check out Île de Frioul. You can buy your tickets at the Vieux Port. Make sure to buy them a few hours in advance because they can sell out during the warmer months. The 1st stop on the boat is Château d'If, which is the castle in the famous French novel, The Tales of Monte Cristo, and the 2nd stop is Frioul. If you want to see the castle, you have to do it on the way to Frioul, as they don't make the 2nd stop on the way back to Marseille. The boat back to the mainland leaves around every hour or so until 9 pm.

Make sure to check the metro times and plan accordingly if you are not planning to stay for the night. The 50 bus back to Aix typically runs until midnight.

How can I find events and things to do in Marseille?

The Instagram account @konetu.magazine https://www.instagram.com/konetu.magazine/ posts events throughout the week in Marseille every Wednesday, the majority of which are free.

Language Immersion

One of the things you might be worried about the most is the process of language immersion. Thankfully, there are lots of ways to immerse yourself at home, even if you aren't living with a host family or with a French roommate. Self-immersion before I left California is also one of the ways I made my transition easier to France. However, even after you arrive, you can still keep up these tips and tricks to improve your French by yourself:

- Do everything possible in French! It might be slow and tedious at first and you might not understand what you're doing or hearing, but bit by bit your brain will passively learn French. Reading, playing video games, listening to music, memorizing song lyrics and singing, podcasts, Duolingo, audio-based app subscriptions like Pimsleur etc. Translate every word that you don't understand.
- Keep a journal in French, or "un journal intime." You don't have to write much, even a couple lines per day or per entry will suffice, and it will be a nice little souvenir of your adventures in Aix-en-Provence.
- Make friends who are native-speakers! Real life practice is a must, and a good chunk of your learning will be done outside of the classroom via experience. For this, it's important to make a few French-speaking friends who are willing to practice with you, and in return maybe you can help them with their English. You may be asking yourself "But where is the best place to make French friends?" since it can be daunting to strike up a conversation with a stranger in public.
  - To meet and make friends with French people, I highly recommend joining a club or signing up for an extra SUAPS class (which are sports, physical activity, or dance classes) at Aix-Marseille Université: https://sport-suaps.univ-amu.fr/sport/list You can take up to two SUAPS classes for free, and many students have found it easier to make French friends when they can bond in an activity-based setting.
  - There is also a Salle de Sport (gym) located right on campus!
- Go to the Language Café on campus and speak English with other students (typically French) who want to learn. The Language Café typically during Tuesdays and Thursdays at lunch (check to see if the times or meeting room has changed). https://www.univ-amu.fr/en/public/welcome-language-cafe
- Get a language exchange partner through the university program Tandem! https://allsh.univ-amu.fr/sites/default/files/media-ressource/tandem_cfal.pdf
- Develop a routine, such as visiting the same boulangerie at the same time every day. You might develop a mutual friendliness with the locals who work there, who will be more willing to talk to you in French since they know you better.
- Never be afraid to practice your French! That's a big part of what you're here for. It's normal to make mistakes or be nervous, but it's all part of the process. If someone switches to English for you to make it easier, you can politely ask them if you can practice in French instead.

« Est-ce que je peux pratiquer mon français avec vous s'il vous plaît ? »

« Je préfère parler en français s'il vous plaît. »

I find that the locals in the south of France are much more willing to accommodate language learners, and they often find it endearing that we are so eager to learn and practice, which can contrast greatly with the attitude in other cities, such as Paris, for example. If you are studying at Aix-Marseille Université, the majority of the students you will encounter at SUL are international students from all over the world, and they often speak English fluently. (How lucky are we to have our native language be the universal language, or lingua franca!) Because of this, unless you are placed in a higher language level at SUL, it can be difficult to only speak French amongst the other students. However, the other students at SUL are typically extremely kind, sweet, and compassionate people with a wide range of life experiences, coming from all different countries, so friendships with other SUL students are very rewarding as well.

French Media Recommendations

Podcasts

For beginner/intermediate learners: Duolingo French Podcast

What I really like about the Duolingo French podcast is that it's partially in English, and there are even transcripts available for each podcast so you can follow along word for word.
https://open.spotify.com/show/2Mu5dTlsG1vRE25twu1P2l

For advanced learners: French Voices Podcast

At the beginning of every podcast, Jessica goes over the difficult vocabulary words in English. The actual podcast itself is interviews with real native French speakers, so you get exposed to a wide range of accents, dialects, and lifestyle related vocabulary in French.
https://open.spotify.com/show/6ZnqRhWRXFvPjQxT8NQLB5

Instagram Accounts

I personally follow over 50 French accounts on Instagram to help me with my language learning. Simply scrolling through social media videos can be very informative and educational if you allow your algorithm to be saturated with language learning videos. Here are a couple of my favorite accounts for learning French:
♡@francaisavecpierre
♡@hellofrenchnyc
♡@atfrenchies

This artice also has good suggestions for accounts to follow:
https://www.private-frenchlessons-paris.com/blog/10-instagram-accounts-to-follow-in-2021-to-learn-french

Music

Here is a playlist I've put together of all the songs that I've discovered since being in France: *https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3TlgCiQycWSCNTpFeCaMG5*

Other Media

One of my favorite comedians is a New Yorker named Sebastian Marx who performs his comedy routines in French. Check out his performance for free on Youtube:

Voici an article I found that really helped me with my accent in French:
https://www.frenchasyoulikeit.com/how-to-improve-your-french-accent-6-practical-tips/

Being a Minority in France

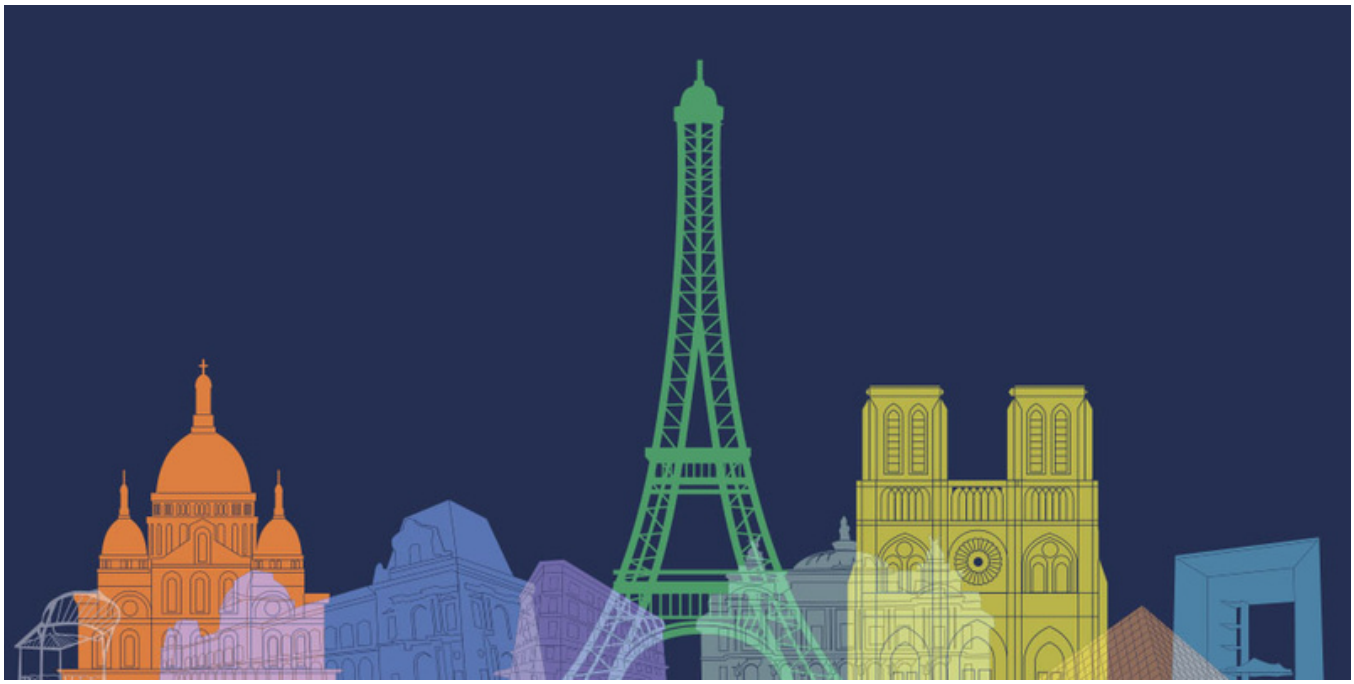
Everyone's experiences will be different, but if you are concerned about the discrimination you may face as a someone who is a person of color, disabled, or a member of the LGBTQ+ community, here's what I can say to you.

Racism, homophobia, transphobia, and ableism is present here in Europe. Students of color have reported feeling more targeted in Aix-en-Provence compared to Marseille. If you are white, please remember to be an ally and to use your privilege to help out other students if you notice they are being treated unfairly.

As a member of the LGBTQ+ community myself, I personally experienced less homophobia here in France compared to what I experience in the United States, but each country in Europe will be different. Homophobia and transphobia are not non-existent, however, so if you are feeling like someone is threatening you, please tell a teacher or a counselor. Teachers in France typically do their best to accommodate name and pronoun changes, but don't be afraid to tell them right at the beginning of class and to correct them if they get it wrong, or else it will be become more difficult for them to learn later on. (iel is the nonbinary pronoun, equivalent to "they" in English. To write gender-inclusive adjectives, use periods. For example: intelligent or intelligente would become "intelligent.e" Gender-inclusive adjectives only work à l'écrit, or while writing.)

Navigating a disability, especially a physical disability that affects mobility, can be difficult while in France because the cities and streets were built long before accessibility laws were put in place. However, Aix-Marseille Université can help with certain academic accommodations. Bring a copy of your diagnosis, a copy of your disability accommodations from your home university, and a French translation of those documents into the Centre de Santé at SIUMPP, located in Le Cube building, and they will be able help you.

Please remember that this is only a fair warning, and not necessarily something you will experience during your séjour here in France. France is relatively a very safe country.



Above all, do your best to stay safe while having fun because:

Le temps passe vite. Profites-en !
(The time passes quickly in France; enjoy.)